

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 7 · CHARACTER

Who someone is, and whether a story is allowed to change them.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

The Godfather · 1972 · 175 min · dir. Francis Ford Coppola ·
written by Mario Puzo & Francis Ford Coppola · Paramount

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*A father and a daughter, thirty-one years apart. Francis Ford Coppola's *The Godfather* follows a young man who swears he is nothing like his family and becomes the head of it, one of the biggest character transformations in film.*

*Sofia Coppola's *Lost in Translation* follows two strangers in a Tokyo hotel who barely change at all, and trusts that being truly seen is enough of a story. One is the full arc. The other is almost no arc.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

THE GODFATHER

1972 · 175 min · dir. Francis Ford Coppola · written by Mario Puzo & Francis Ford Coppola · Paramount

The youngest son of a New York crime family wants nothing to do with the business. Then someone tries to kill his father.

Why it is on the ballot. Michael Corleone's change, from war-hero outsider to the coldest man in the room, is the textbook character arc run in reverse. Every step is visible and every step is a choice. It is three hours long and you will not feel it.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE STUDIO HAD TO BE PUSHED INTO BOTH CASTINGS

Paramount resisted Marlon Brando, then seen as difficult and box-office poison, and made him screen-test, take low pay and post a bond. Executives wanted Redford, Beatty or Delon for Michael and thought Al Pacino too short. Coppola was close enough to being replaced that he started firing the people angling to replace him. Pacino nearly broke his ankle early in the shoot and was relieved, hoping it might get him fired.

BRANDO BUILT THE FACE HIMSELF

At his home screen test Brando stuffed cotton wool in his cheeks and blacked his hair with shoe polish. For the film he wore a custom dental “plumper” designed by makeup artist Dick Smith and made by a New York dentist. It is now in the collection of the Museum of the Moving Image.

THE DARKNESS IS A STYLE

Gordon Willis lit many scenes from directly overhead, leaving the characters’ eyes in shadow, an idea that came out of the Brando test: you do not always want to know what this man is thinking. Cinematographers nicknamed him “the Prince of Darkness.” Watch how often you cannot read a face.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE WEDDING

Where is Michael standing?

At his sister's wedding Michael is in his army uniform, off to the side, explaining his family to his girlfriend like an outsider. "That's my family, Kay. It's not me."

Why it matters: It is the starting point of the arc, and the film puts him at the edge of the frame to say so.

THE HOSPITAL

Steady hands

Michael finds his father unguarded and stands watch outside with a terrified baker. Enzo cannot work the lighter; Michael lights it for him, then looks at his own hand.

Why it matters: The other man is shaking. Michael is not. It is the moment he, and you, find out who he really is.

THE RESTAURANT

The train

Michael sits down to dinner with two men. Listen to the elevated train outside getting louder, and notice that the Italian is not subtitled.

Why it matters: No music, no translation. The rising noise is his head. The sound tells you what he has decided before he moves. Paramount only stopped trying to replace Pacino after seeing the dailies from this scene.

Michael stands in a church as godfather to his nephew, renouncing Satan, while the film cuts away to what is happening across the city.

Why it matters: The arc completes inside one sequence, cut by William Reynolds and Peter Zinner. He becomes the Godfather in both senses at the same moment.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The baby in the baptism is Sofia Coppola

The infant christened as Michael Francis Rizzi is Francis Ford Coppola's daughter, who grew up to direct the other film in this chapter.

OPEN

The horse's head was real

It came from a dog-food plant in New Jersey, from a horse that was being put down anyway, and was shipped packed in dry ice. The story that John Marley was not told and screamed for real is not confirmed by any solid source.

OPEN

Eleven nominations became ten, and three wins

It won Best Picture, Best Adapted Screenplay and Best Actor. Brando declined the award and sent Sacheen Littlefeather to speak about the treatment of Native Americans in film; the Academy issued her a formal written apology in 2022. Nino Rota's score was nominated and then withdrawn when the Academy learned the love theme came from his music for *Fortunella* (1958).

01 Michael says "It's not me" in the first scene. At what exact moment does it become him?

02 Is Michael's story a hero's journey, or the same journey run backwards?

03 The film makes you root for a family of murderers. How does it do that?

Where to watch

Find it here → [The Godfather on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: AFI Catalog · the Academy's awards database · Museum of the Moving Image · American Cinematographer · Variety

THE LESSON

ONE JOURNEY, A THOUSAND FACES

A SCHOLAR DESCRIBED THE WORLD'S MYTHS

In 1949 Joseph Campbell published *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, comparing myths from around the world and arguing they share one pattern, the “monomyth” — a term he borrowed from James Joyce. A hero leaves the ordinary world, is tested, is transformed, comes home changed. It was comparative mythology, not a writing manual.

A STUDIO MEMO MADE IT A FORMULA

George Lucas credited Campbell for *Star Wars* and called him “my Yoda.” Then, in the mid-1980s, Christopher Vogler, a story analyst at Disney, wrote a seven-page memo called “A Practical Guide to The Hero with a Thousand Faces,” turning Campbell into twelve steps for screenwriters. It circulated through Hollywood, and in 1992 he expanded it into the book *The Writer's Journey*. A description of ancient myths became a checklist for development meetings.

THE RULE IT CREATED

The checklist brought an assumption with it: a main character must change. Want something, learn what they really need, come out different. A story where nobody changes started to look, to a development executive, like a story that was not finished.

THREE WAYS A CHARACTER CAN MOVE

ONE

THE RISE

The character overcomes a flaw and ends up better. The classic hero's journey.

Star Wars · The Lion King · Moana

TWO

THE FALL

The same steps run downhill. The character gets what they want and loses who they were.

The Godfather · There Will Be Blood · Breaking Bad

THREE

THE FLAT LINE

The character barely changes. Instead the story reveals them, or they change the people around them.

Lost in Translation · Paddington · Paterson

The third one is the hardest to sell and the easiest to love.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Writers separate a character's **want**, what they chase, from their **need**, what would actually fix them. Michael wants to protect his father. What he needs is to stay out. Watch which one each film cares about.

WHY THESE FILMS

Part Three starts with the person at the centre. A father made the most famous fall in film. His daughter made a film about two people who refuse to transform, and won an Oscar for it.

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S FILM FORUM

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Academy's awards database, the Museum of the Moving Image, American Cinematographer, Variety and MovieMaker. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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